

The Unseen · Narrated Version

Nebula Prophecy style · cold open + 6 chapters

Target word count: 2,400 (range 2,280–2,520)

Final word count: 2,409 spoken words (2,174 narration + 235 dialogue; chapter titles and sound cues not counted). About 16 min of speech at 2.5 wps, plus music and action breaks, for about 19–20 min total.

Plain paragraphs = narrator · shaded lines = character dialogue · italics in brackets = sound cues

COLD OPEN

ANUK They say the jungle takes whoever it wants. I never believed them.

[music]

CHAPTER 1: THE SILENT TAKING

The scream comes just before dawn.

It cuts through the village of Kanai like a blade, and then it stops. Just stops.

By the time the men arrive with torches, the hut at the edge of the forest is empty. The fire is still warm. A clay bowl lies shattered on the floor. And on the doorframe, carved deep into the wood, are four long claw marks.

HUNTER Four marks again. Same as the others.

Nobody saw anything. Nobody heard footsteps. Whatever came out of that jungle came in silence, and it left the same way.

This is the sixth person in a single moon.

At first, the village told itself it was a jaguar. Then a pack of wild dogs. But jaguars leave tracks. Dogs leave blood. This thing leaves nothing. No body. No trail. Only those four marks, and a strange sweet smell that hangs in the air long after it's gone.

And now, the people of Kanai have a name for it. They call it the Unseen.

Mothers stop letting their children play past the fence. Hunters stop hunting. Every night, the whole village gathers around one great fire, backs to the flames, spears facing the dark. And every few nights, someone still disappears.

[music]

The elder, Moro, calls a council.

He is the oldest man in Kanai, and the most feared. His voice is soft, but when he speaks, nobody interrupts.

MORO The forest spirits are angry. The Unseen is a curse, sent to punish us. And a curse can only be broken one way.

MORO It must be hunted. And it must be killed.

Every eye turns to the same young man.

His name is Anuk. He is barely twenty, but there is no one in Kanai faster with a bow. He has tracked boar through rivers. He has brought down a jaguar with a single arrow. The children follow him everywhere. The older hunters pretend not to be jealous.

But Anuk carries something else, too. Around his neck hangs a small pendant of carved bone, shaped like a spiral. It belonged to his mother. Twelve years ago, she walked into the forest to gather herbs, and she never came back. The village said the jungle took her.

Anuk was eight years old.

MORO Anuk. Bring me the heart of the Unseen, and the curse will end.

ANUK I will go.

That night, his little sister Lani ties a red cord around his wrist so the spirits will recognize him.

LANI Promise you'll come home.

ANUK I promise.

He has no idea how hard that promise is going to be to keep.

CHAPTER 2: INTO THE DEEP JUNGLE

At first light, Anuk leaves Kanai with his bow, a quiver of twenty arrows, a stone knife, and a waterskin. The whole village watches him go. Moro watches longest of all.

[music]

The deep jungle is nothing like the hunting grounds near the village.

Here, the trees are so tall that the sun barely touches the ground. The air is thick and wet. Every sound is too loud, and every silence is worse. Anuk moves slowly, reading the ground the way his father taught him. Broken twigs. Bent leaves. Disturbed moss.

And for most of the first day, he finds nothing.

Then, near a stream, he finds the first sign. A strip of woven cloth caught on a thorn bush.

ANUK Cloth from Kanai. The fisherman's.

It belonged to the fisherman who vanished two weeks ago. A few steps further, there's another. And another. Like someone was dragged this way.

But something is wrong. The trail is too clean. There are no animal prints. No claw marks in the mud. Just the flattened plants of something heavy being pulled... and here and there, a footprint. A human footprint.

ANUK It must be his. It has to be.

He keeps going.

But the jungle tries to stop him first. Crossing a clearing of black mud, he sinks to his knees, then to his waist. The more he fights, the faster it pulls.

[screaming]

Anuk forces himself to go still. He reaches, slowly, for a hanging root, and inch by inch, drags himself free. He lies on the bank, gasping, covered in mud. One wrong move, and no one in Kanai would ever have known what happened to him.

[music]

By nightfall, he's deep in territory no one from Kanai has entered in a generation. He climbs a tree to sleep, ties himself to a branch, and closes his eyes.

That's when he hears it.

[breathing]

A low sound. Not a growl. More like breathing. Deep, slow, and very close.

Anuk opens his eyes. Moonlight falls through the leaves. And the branches right next to him... move. Not with the wind. With something. Something shaped like the forest itself, the same colors, the same patterns, a shape he can barely see even when he's staring straight at it.

It's right there. Close enough to touch.

He doesn't breathe. His hand slides toward his knife.

And then, just like that, the shape melts back into the dark. Gone.

ANUK It was right beside me. And I couldn't see it.

Anuk doesn't sleep again that night.

CHAPTER 3: EYES OF AMBER

The next morning, he starts the hunt for real.

He knows now what the villagers never understood. The Unseen isn't invisible. It's camouflaged. It blends into the jungle so perfectly that the eye just slides off it. So he stops looking with his eyes. He listens. He watches the birds, because birds go quiet

around predators. He watches the insects, because they scatter when something big passes.

And slowly, he learns its path.

For two days he follows it. Twice he gets close. The first time, he steps on a hidden branch and the creature vanishes before he can draw. The second time, he isn't so lucky.

He's crossing a fallen log above a ravine when the world explodes.

[crash]

Something slams into the log from below. It snaps. Anuk falls, crashing through vines, hitting the mud hard. His bow flies out of his hands. And above him, clinging to the rock wall, the Unseen finally shows itself.

It's enormous. Twice the size of a jaguar. Its skin shifts in waves of green and brown and gold, like leaves in moving light. Its eyes are huge and amber. And its claws, four on each foot, are exactly the length of the marks on the doorframes of Kanai.

It drops down in front of him.

Anuk grabs his knife. He knows it won't be enough. The creature lowers its head, lips pulling back from rows of teeth...

[music]

...and then it stops.

It's staring at his chest. At the bone pendant hanging from his neck.

For a long, strange moment, neither of them moves. The creature leans closer. It breathes in, slowly, like it's smelling something it remembers. Then it makes a sound Anuk has never heard an animal make.

[soft cry]

Low. Soft. Almost like grief.

And it turns and leaves him alive.

ANUK Why didn't you kill me? Why?

But what he's about to discover will make that question seem small.

CHAPTER 4: THE IRON CAMP

On the fourth day, Anuk reaches a river wider than any he has ever seen. And on the far bank, hidden by a bend in the water, there is a camp.

Not a village. A camp. Tents made of hides. Cages made of bamboo. And iron. Anuk has only ever seen iron once, on a trader's knife. Here there are iron chains, iron spears, iron pots over the fires.

Men with painted faces walk between the cages. Strangers. Traders from somewhere far down the river.

And inside the cages... are people.

Anuk creeps closer through the reeds. His heart is pounding. Because he knows these faces. The fisherman. The weaver's daughter. Old Tamu, who went to check his traps a month ago. All of them. Alive. Thin, frightened, chained... but alive.

TAMU Anuk? Boy, is that you? No beast took us. Men did.

The Unseen didn't take them.

At the far end of the camp, there's one more cage. Smaller than the rest, covered with a heavy hide. Something inside it is crying. A thin, high sound. Anuk has heard that sound before. Low. Soft. Almost like grief. Only smaller.

[music]

Then Anuk sees something that turns his blood to ice.

A canoe pulls up to the bank. Two men climb out. They're from Kanai. They're Moro's personal guards. And one of them is carrying a strange object. A wooden glove, with four sharp bone claws lashed to the fingers.

GUARD One scratch of this glove on a doorframe, and they blame the monster.

TRADER LEADER Your people are fools. Savages trading their own blood for metal.

Now everything makes sense. The human footprints. The trail that was too clean. The sweet smell, which Anuk now recognizes as the sleeping herb that healers use. The villagers were never taken by a beast. They were drugged, dragged away, and sold. Sold to these traders in exchange for iron. And Moro invented the curse to hide it.

The Unseen was never the monster.

It was just the perfect thing to blame.

GUARD Remember the healer? The one with the bone spiral? She tried to warn them.

TRADER LEADER Moro sold her first. She fetched a good price.

Anuk's hand closes around the pendant. His mother didn't vanish in the jungle. She was sold. And the creature knew her. She was a healer who could calm the beasts of the forest. That's why it spared him. It recognized her scent on the bone.

The Unseen isn't hunting the village. It's been hunting the men who take villagers. The same men who took its young. Guarding the forest, the same way his mother once did.

CHAPTER 5: A PACT WITHOUT WORDS

And now Anuk has a choice.

He could go home. Tell no one. Bring back some animal's heart, collect his honor, and live safely under Moro for the rest of his life. Or he could stand against the most powerful man in Kanai, and a camp full of armed traders, alone.

Except... he isn't alone.

That night, Anuk walks into the jungle unarmed and sits down in a clearing. He holds up his mother's pendant. And he waits.

ANUK She was my mother. They took her from both of us.

For a long time, nothing happens.

Then the leaves in front of him ripple, and two amber eyes open in the dark.

[music]

The creature approaches slowly. It sniffs the pendant again. Then it does something extraordinary. It lowers its huge head and presses its forehead against Anuk's hand.

A pact, without words.

Just before dawn, they strike.

Anuk moves through the reeds on the river's edge while the Unseen disappears into the trees above the camp. The first guard never even sees what hits him. Then the second. The traders wake to chaos. Tents collapse. Torches fall. Something massive, something they can't see, tears through the camp like a storm.

TRADER Something's in the trees! I can't see it!

In the confusion, Anuk reaches the cages. He smashes the locks with a rock and drags the chains free. One by one, the prisoners stumble out. The fisherman. The weaver's daughter. Old Tamu, tears in his eyes.

He saves the last cage for the end. He pulls back the hide. Inside, curled in the corner, is a young Unseen, no bigger than a dog, its skin flickering with fear. The moment the door opens, it bolts for the trees.

ANUK Go, little one. Go to her.

But the traders aren't finished.

Their leader, a huge man with an iron spear, spots Anuk at the last cage. He charges. Anuk draws his bow and fires. The arrow glances off the man's iron chest plate. Anuk has one arrow left, and no time to use it.

TRADER LEADER Your arrows mean nothing against iron.

The spear comes down.
And it never lands.

[roar]

The Unseen explodes out of the shadows and throws the trader across the camp. But the man is fast. As he falls, he drives his spear upward, deep into the creature's side. The Unseen roars. For the first time, its camouflage fails. Its skin flashes red and black, and every man in the camp finally sees what they've been fearing all along. Anuk nocks his last arrow. He steadies his breathing, just like his father taught him. He fires.

The trader falls, and doesn't get up.

The rest of them run. They pile into their boats and push off downriver, and they don't look back.

Silence.

Anuk kneels beside the Unseen. The wound is deep, but it's still breathing. He tears a strip from his cloak and presses it into the wound. He crushes healing leaves from the traders' own supplies, the ones his mother would have known by heart. And slowly, the bleeding stops.

ANUK Stay with me. I've got you.

The creature looks at him with those huge amber eyes. Then it slips back into the jungle, its skin turns green again, and it's gone.

CHAPTER 6: THE TRUTH RETURNS

Three days later, Anuk walks back into Kanai.

He isn't alone. Behind him come the fisherman, the weaver's daughter, Old Tamu, and eleven others. People the village had already mourned. People everyone thought were dead.

The village goes silent. Then Lani screams his name and runs into his arms.

LANI Anuk! Anuk!

Moro stands at the center of the village. His face is white.

MORO A miracle! The curse is broken!

But Anuk walks up to him and throws the wooden claw glove at his feet.

ANUK Here is your beast, Elder. Four claws. Carved by your own guards.

And one by one, the rescued villagers step forward and tell everyone exactly what happened. The sleeping herbs. The chains. The iron. The names of every person Moro

sold.

Including Anuk's mother.

Nobody in Kanai speaks for Moro. Not one person. That same day, the village takes his staff, his feathers, and his home, and they send him into the jungle alone. The same jungle he blamed for everything.

MORO No... not the jungle. Not alone.

[music]

Whether the Unseen finds him, nobody ever knows.

Months pass. Kanai heals. The children play past the fence again. And for the first time in years, the village has nothing to fear in the forest.

Anuk still goes into the deep jungle. Not to hunt. Not anymore.

Every new moon, he walks to the clearing by the river, and he sits, and he waits. And sometimes, if he's patient, the leaves ripple... and two amber eyes open in the dark.

LANI You didn't bring back the heart.

ANUK No. I brought back the truth.

[breathing]